#LAKESOFLADAKH

MOUNTAIN BLUES



In the far reaches of Ladakh, three legendary lakes beckon. With the Mercedes-Benz GLC 300 as a companion, this is a journey through silence, altitude, and reflection, where water and engineering meet in perfect harmony

By **ABHINAV JAKHAR**

In Ladakh, stillness is not a lack of movement; it is a profound state of being. It is a presence of air, of scale, of silence so deep it echoes in your thoughts. Across this towering, stark, and lunar expanse lie three lakes that don't just define the landscape—they elevate it: Pangong Tso, Tso Moriri, and Tso Kar. Each is a mirror of Ladakh's many moods, each more remote than the last. And to chase them is to understand that the journey is as much about the road between them as the water itself. The journey began from Jispa, on a frigid and damp early morning with an eerie silence.

At its heart was a 2.0-litre, four-cylinder, turbocharged petrol engine, mated to a mild-hybrid system that brought both responsiveness and refinement. The power was immediate but never urgent—a surge when needed, a whisper when not. The first stretch of road towards Chang La Pass rose slowly, then suddenly. Tarmac gave way to gravel, and the weather teased with uncertainty. But the GLC 300 4MATIC never flinched. It carried on its pursuit of providing modern-day explorers with a penchant for luxury and class.

As the elevation increased, so did the terrain's hostility. Steep gradients, rockfall-prone stretches, icy rivulets across the road - each bend demanded attention. The GLC 300 answered not with brute force but with balance. Its 4MATIC all-wheel-drive system didn't simply react; it anticipated. Beyond Chang La, the landscape opened like a cracked canvas. Flat valleys stretched to oblivion, only to be suddenly interrupted by jagged peaks. And there, breaking through this wild monochrome, was Pangong Tso.

Stretching over 130 kilometres, with two-thirds lying in Tibet, Pangong is not just a lake—it's an optical illusion. The road to Tso Moriri is less a route and more a negotiation. After a while, the lines on the map begin to disappear, and with them, all expectations of what roads should look like. The GLC 300 felt more like a capsule than a car, easily driving through sand, crossing streams, and handling all kinds of changing terrain.

The perfectly tuned suspension soaked up unpredictability with grace. The 9-speed automatic transmission shifted intuitively, always in sync with the rhythm of the terrain. Eventually, beyond the bends of Korzok, the land relaxed its grip, and Tso Moriri emerged.

If Pangong was the performance, Moriri was the prayer.